



# Problem Solving in Consulting

Tuck Business Bridge Program  
Summer 2026



# Andy Kaestle

Proud father of 3, former consultant, T'17, enthusiastic career advisor



## Pre-2005

Seattle, WA

Grew up in the PNW



## 2009-2015

New York, NY / Zurich, CH

Financial Due Diligence Manager, non-profit board work, Kiva Microfunds (Philippines)



## 2017-2021

Dallas, TX / Hanover, NH

Bain Senior Manager, travel, second kid (Hannah), back to Hanover (remote with Bain)



## 2005-2009

San Diego, CA

USD, accounting, finance, football, school newspaper editor



## 2015-2017

Hanover, NH

Married, MBA at Tuck, tripod hockey, student board, first kid (Will)



## 2021-present

Back to Tuck!

Tuck Lecturer, Career Services (consulting), family, skiing, camping, hiking, third kid (Samantha)







- | Player Number   | Player Name     |
|-----------------|-----------------|
| 8               | [Name obscured] |
| 12              | [Name obscured] |
| 4               | [Name obscured] |
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| 5               | [Name obscured] |





# **Our goals for this session**

- **Introduction to structured problem solving**
- **Problem solving walkthrough**
- **Structuring essentials and practice**
- **High-impact communication: presentation development and delivery**
- **Wrap-up and Q&A**



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# Structured problem solving is a critical skill to learn and practice – you will use it frequently

1



**Clarify the  
objective**

2



**Develop a  
workplan**

3



**Gather  
information**

4



**Analyze info,  
extract insights**

5



**Recommend,  
support action**



You will use this when approaching challenges   
in your coursework, including Bridge

1



**Clarify the  
objective**

*Student* reads case, giving particular attention to the situation, complication, and key questions

2



**Develop a  
workplan**

*Student* develops a hypothesis, identifies analyses that will help validate or disprove that hypothesis

3



**Gather  
information**

*Student* compiles information from the case and appendices needed to conduct the prescribed analyses

4



**Analyze info,  
extract insights**

*Student* performs calculations, interprets charts, brainstorms ideas, etc., refines hypothesis as needed

5



**Recommend,  
support action**

*Student* synthesizes insights, formulates a well-supported answer to the key case question



If you apply for consulting jobs, you will also leverage this process **during case interviews**



1



**Clarify the objective**

*Interviewer* delivers prompt, *interviewee* asks clarifying questions

2



**Develop a workplan**

*Interviewee* builds an approach to solve the problem (i.e. structure)

3



**Gather information**

*Interviewee* investigates select areas, *interviewer* collaborates

4



**Analyze info, extract insights**

*Interviewee* digests info, exhibits, data, etc. and performs analysis (i.e. math)

5



**Recommend, support action**

*Interviewee* synthesizes insights, makes recommendations





Most critically, regardless of where you land a  job, you will use this to **perform well at work**

1



**Clarify the  
objective**

*Employee encounters a problem, works to better understand the core underlying issue*

2



**Develop a  
workplan**

*Employee develops a hypothesis, identifies analyses that will help validate or disprove that hypothesis*

3



**Gather  
information**

*Employee compiles information from internal and external sources needed to conduct analyses*

4



**Analyze info,  
extract insights**

*Employee performs calculations, interprets data, brainstorms ideas, etc., refines hypothesis as needed*

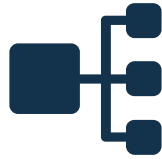
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**Recommend,  
support action**

*Employee synthesizes insights, formulates and delivers a well-supported approach to address the issue*

# Being an effective problem solver requires two important, foundational skills



## Strong problem solving

- Structured
- Numerate and logical
- Creative and insightful

**Can you solve  
the problem efficiently  
and effectively?**



## Compelling communication

- Articulate speaker
- Good listener
- Credible

**Can you build  
consensus and  
persuade others to act?**



# Each of these overarching skills require building specific competencies for **problem solving**...

| Dimension                     | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Structuring</b>            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Focus on the right question; break it down into an exhaustive set of independent drivers</li><li>• Provide an approach to solving the problem</li></ul>                                                                                              |
| <b>Numeracy</b>               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Lay out a clear and optimal analytical approach</li><li>• Sound, error-free analysis, done efficiently</li><li>• Identify implications of the analysis on the problem you are trying to solve</li></ul>                                              |
| <b>Judgement and insights</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Connect findings and insights to begin developing sound recommendations</li><li>• Make, and update, reasonable hypotheses</li><li>• Also identify implications on the client's business, including risks and implementation considerations</li></ul> |
| <b>Creativity</b>             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Develop numerous and varied sound ideas, organize them in a prioritized and structured manner</li></ul>                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Synthesis</b>              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Formulate a clear and sound recommendation that can be delivered in a convincing way</li><li>• Support your recommendation with key points, followed by specific next steps</li></ul>                                                                |
| <b>Leadership</b>             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Progress through the problem-solving process swiftly and confidently</li><li>• Stay focused on the key question or problem you are trying to solve</li><li>• Develop an answer (i.e. hypothesis) early on</li></ul>                                  |



# ...as well as executive presence and effective communication

| Dimension     | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Presence      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Be professional, engaging, energetic and confident</li><li>• Build genuine rapport with your team and client</li><li>• Show positive personality</li><li>• Display expert-like credibility</li></ul>                                     |
| Communication | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Listen well, incorporate what you learn into your problem-solving process</li><li>• Speak accurately, specifically and concisely</li><li>• Be organized</li><li>• Share insights before process</li><li>• Communicate visually</li></ul> |



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# Let's first use an example to highlight some of the critical pieces of this process

- Let's say you are working for a company called FitX, a UK-based medical devices manufacturer that specializes in making consumer-focused wearable devices, such as heart rate monitors, step counters, sleep trackers, etc.
- Up until now, FitX has chosen to focus exclusively on customers passionate about fitness
- The research and development team has come up with an idea for a new product: an electronic body fat calculator that uses an electric current to produce highly accurate readings
- **You are working on a team that is tasked with trying to figure out if FitX should go forward with developing and marketing the new product**



Before we hop into solving the problem, **what may we first want to better understand?**

1



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**Analyze info,  
extract insights**

5



**Recommend,  
support action**



# Before we hop into solving the problem, **what may we first want to better understand?**

|                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>BUSINESS MODEL</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Where is FitX based, and which countries do they operate in?</li><li>• Does FitX sell the products to fitness aficionados directly, or via retailers?</li></ul>                                     |
| <b>OBJECTIVE</b>      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Has FitX set a specific objective to consider this product launch successful, for instance a revenue, market share or profit target?</li><li>• What is their timeline to reach this goal?</li></ul> |
| <b>SCOPE</b>          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Is FitX open to changing some of its business model, if needed, to make this launch successful? For instance, are they open to new geographies or selling via different channels?</li></ul>         |



Next, what are some things we would want to analyze to help us answer our key question?

1



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objective**

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**Analyze info,  
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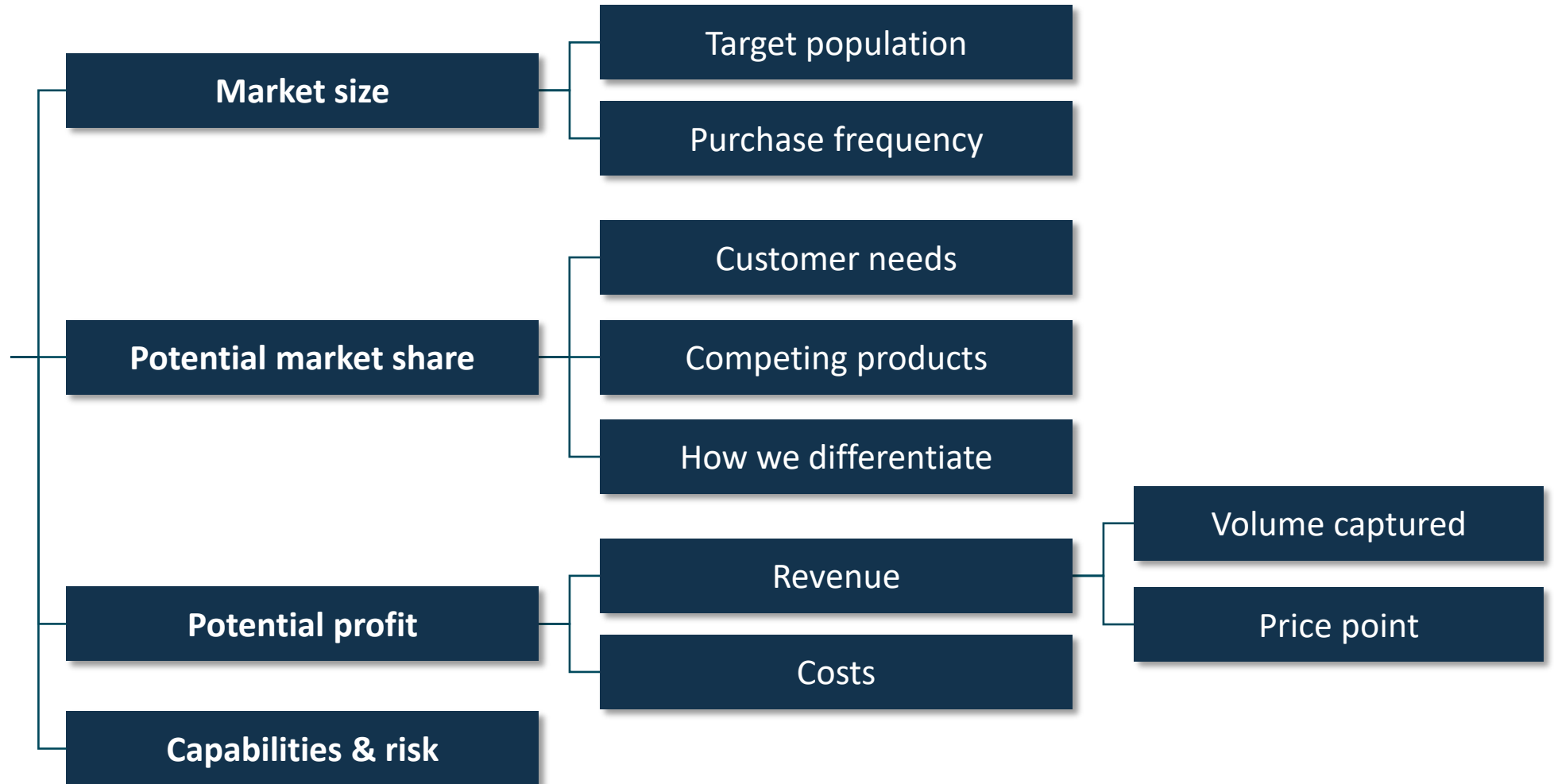


**Recommend,  
support action**



To keep us focused on the right analyses, we should **organize our ideas**

**SHOULD FITX GO  
FORWARD WITH  
DEVELOPING &  
MARKETING  
THE NEW  
PRODUCT?**





Now we are ready to **gather** some information  
that will allow us to **perform analysis**

1



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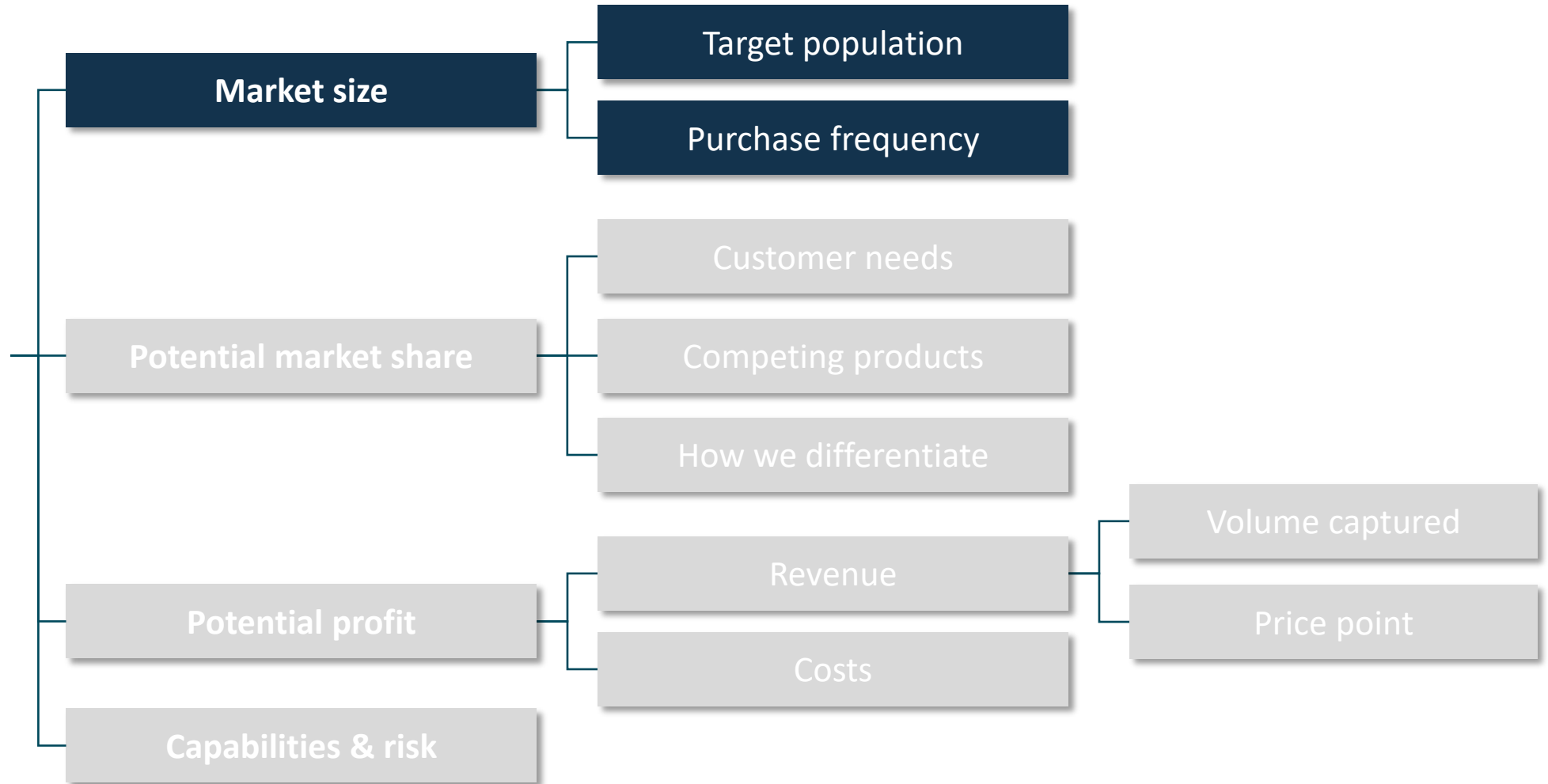
**Recommend,  
support action**





We had said that understanding the **size of the market** was important, let's start there...

SHOULD FITX GO  
FORWARD WITH  
DEVELOPING &  
MARKETING  
THE NEW  
PRODUCT?





...by thinking through what the size of this market might be

**Market size** = Number of products sold per year x Price of the product

 UK population  
... who are into fitness  
... care about their body fat %  
... and would buy a device  
... each year



Tuck

If secondary information is not available, we could perform a quick **market sizing exercise**

|                                                          |                                                                        |                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>UK POPULATION</b>                                     | 60 M                                                                   |                                                                                                                               |
| <b>...INTO FITNESS<br/>AND CARE ABOUT<br/>BODY FAT %</b> | 0% of 0-20 year-olds<br>4% of 20-40 year-olds<br>1% of 40-80 year-olds | $= 0\% \times (25\% \times 60M) = 0.0M$<br>$= 4\% \times (25\% \times 60M) = 0.6M$<br>$= 1\% \times (50\% \times 60M) = 0.3M$ |
| <b>...WHO WOULD<br/>BUY THIS</b>                         | 50%                                                                    | $50\% \times 0.9M = 0.45M$                                                                                                    |
| <b>...EACH YEAR</b>                                      | 1 device every 3 years                                                 | $0.45M/3 = 150,000$                                                                                                           |



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Assuming ~£50 per unit, we can now estimate the size of the market in revenue, GBP

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Market size} &= \text{Number of products sold per year} \times \text{Price of the product} \\ &= 150,000 \times £50 \\ &= \text{£7,500,000}\end{aligned}$$

It's also possible that there is data available on the size of the market, which we can look at...



What do you notice about the **market size** and **landscape** that might be helpful to us?

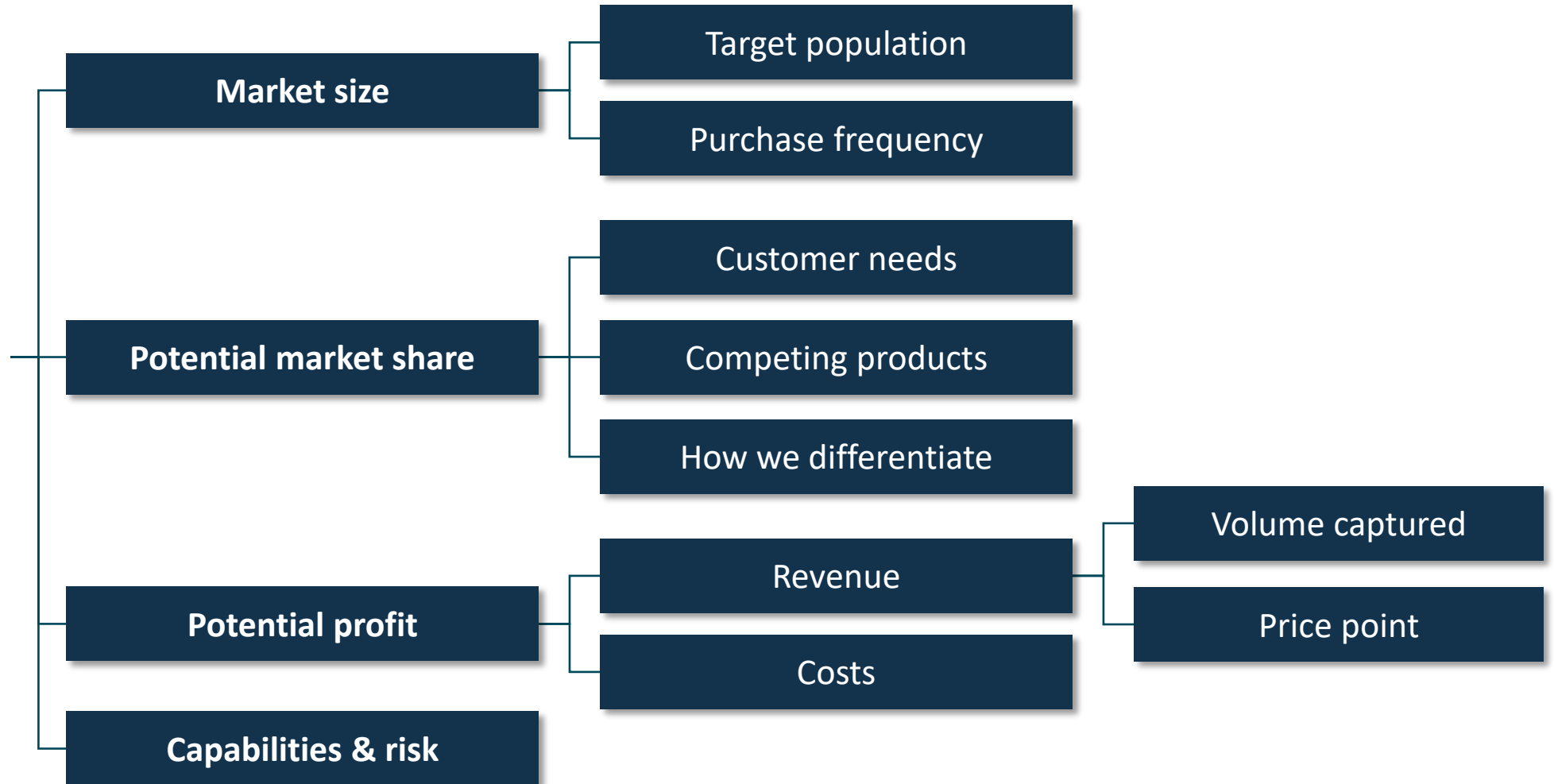
## UK SALES VOLUME FOR ELECTRONIC BODY FAT CALCULATORS

(number of units sold)

| Competitor | 4 years ago | 3 years ago | 2 years ago | 1 year ago | This year (est.) |
|------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|------------|------------------|
| Hoop Band  | 18,200      | 28,800      | 36,500      | 42,800     | 44,000           |
| Wrist Bit  | 18,000      | 29,600      | 34,900      | 42,800     | 43,000           |
| Orange     | 9,000       | 11,200      | 17,100      | 21,500     | 23,000           |
| Garmino    | 19,000      | 17,100      | 17,200      | 18,500     | 18,500           |
| Others     | 28,000      | 25,100      | 25,300      | 25,500     | 26,000           |
| Total      | 92,200      | 111,800     | 131,000     | 151,100    | 154,500          |

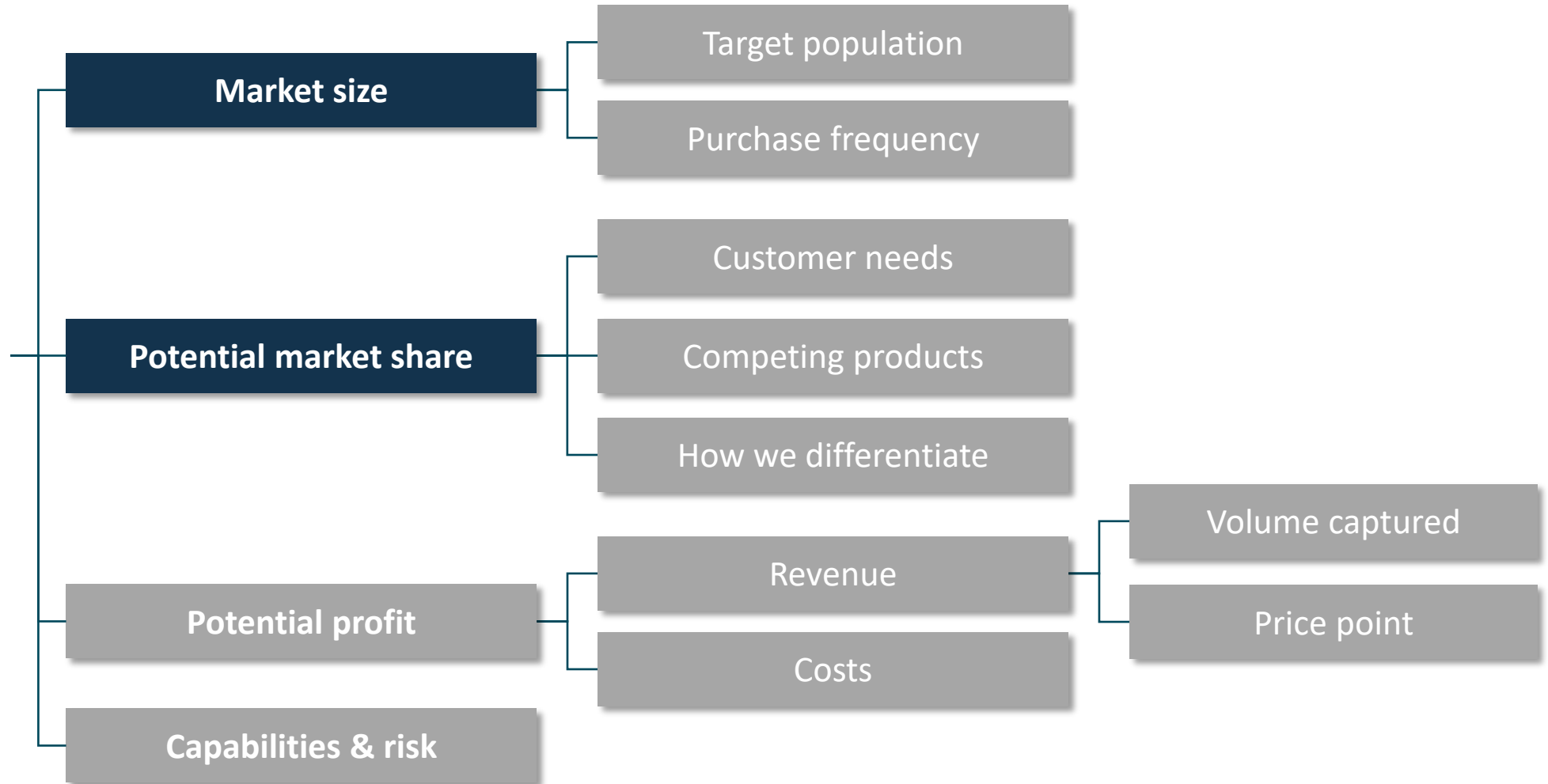
Earlier, we identified several things that were important for us to consider...

SHOULD FITX GO  
FORWARD WITH  
DEVELOPING &  
MARKETING  
THE NEW  
PRODUCT?



Earlier, we identified several things that were important for us to consider...

**SHOULD FITX GO  
FORWARD WITH  
DEVELOPING &  
MARKETING  
THE NEW  
PRODUCT?**





...could we **do anything else** with this data that would help us answer our question?

## UK SALES VOLUME FOR ELECTRONIC BODY FAT CALCULATORS

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Before we recommend not moving forward, let's brainstorm some ideas we may want to consider

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**Recommend,  
support action**



# What else could FitX consider to help reach it's target revenue goal for this product?

| Dimension | Ideas                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hardware  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Add-on services: medical hot line, app subscription</li><li>• Products: meal plans</li></ul>                                        |
| Function  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Glucose level, proteins, vitamins</li></ul>                                                                                         |
| Wearable  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Mid-size devices for gyms, nutritionists, personal trainers, GPs, employers</li></ul>                                               |
| Customer  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• People pursuing weight loss, have a health condition, have ailments correlated with weight (e.g., diabetes), taking GLP1s</li></ul> |
| Geography | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• In other countries (e.g., other EU countries, the US, etc.)</li></ul>                                                               |



# We are now ready to formulate a well-structured recommendation

1



**Clarify the  
objective**

2



**Develop a  
workplan**

3



**Gather  
information**

4



**Analyze info,  
extract insights**

5



**Recommend,  
support action**

# Structure is important – answer the question, provide key supporting points, and next steps

|                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>QUESTION</b>          | <i>We were asked whether FitX should develop and launch a new electronic body fat calculator.</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>ANSWER</b>            | <i>We recommend that FitX hold off on launching the product at this stage.</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>SUPPORTING POINTS</b> | <i>This is for two reasons.</i> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><i>• First, the market size is only £7.5m within the UK. We would need to take more than half the market in order to reach £4m revenue in five years</i></li><li><i>• Second, the market is not growing anymore and quite concentrated with strong and consolidating competitors.</i></li></ul> |
| <b>NEXT STEPS</b>        | <i>There might however be opportunities to broaden the target market. As a next step, we'd suggest FitX evaluate other options to make the revenue goal more realistic – such as selling internationally, or targeting different customer segments.</i>                                                                                                               |



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Crafting a well-structured approach is challenging, yet vital to effective problem-solving

1



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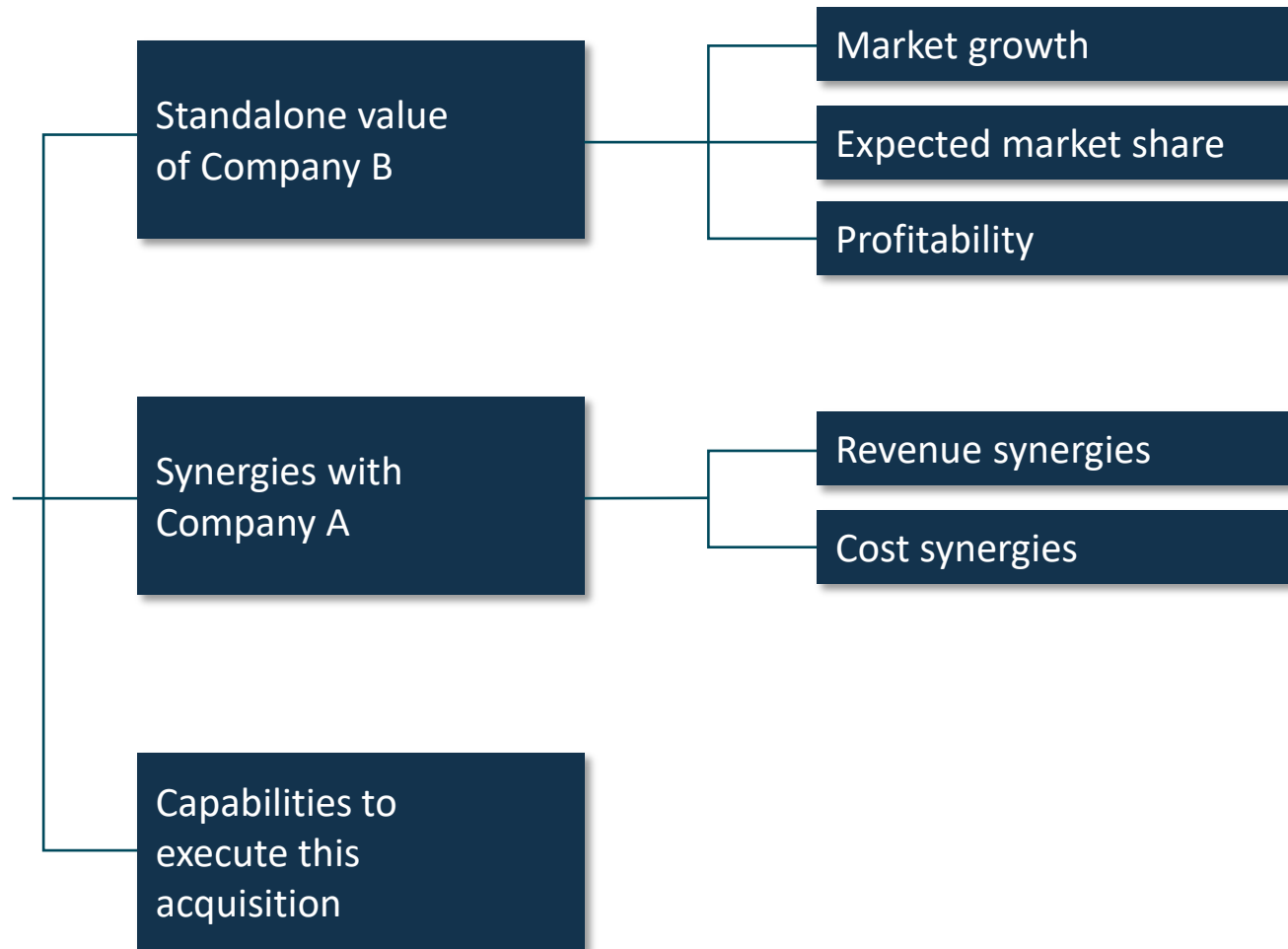
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**Recommend,  
support action**

# Let's examine this step of the process through a typical business example

**SHOULD COMPANY A  
ACQUIRE COMPANY B  
AS PART OF ITS  
GROWTH STRATEGY?**





# We should focus on the answer, offer company-specific insights, and avoid redundancy

- Focus on the right question
- Break down the question into an exhaustive set of independent drivers
- Provide an approach to solving the problem
- Share helpful insights



**A** Answer-focused

**I** Insightful

**M** MECE





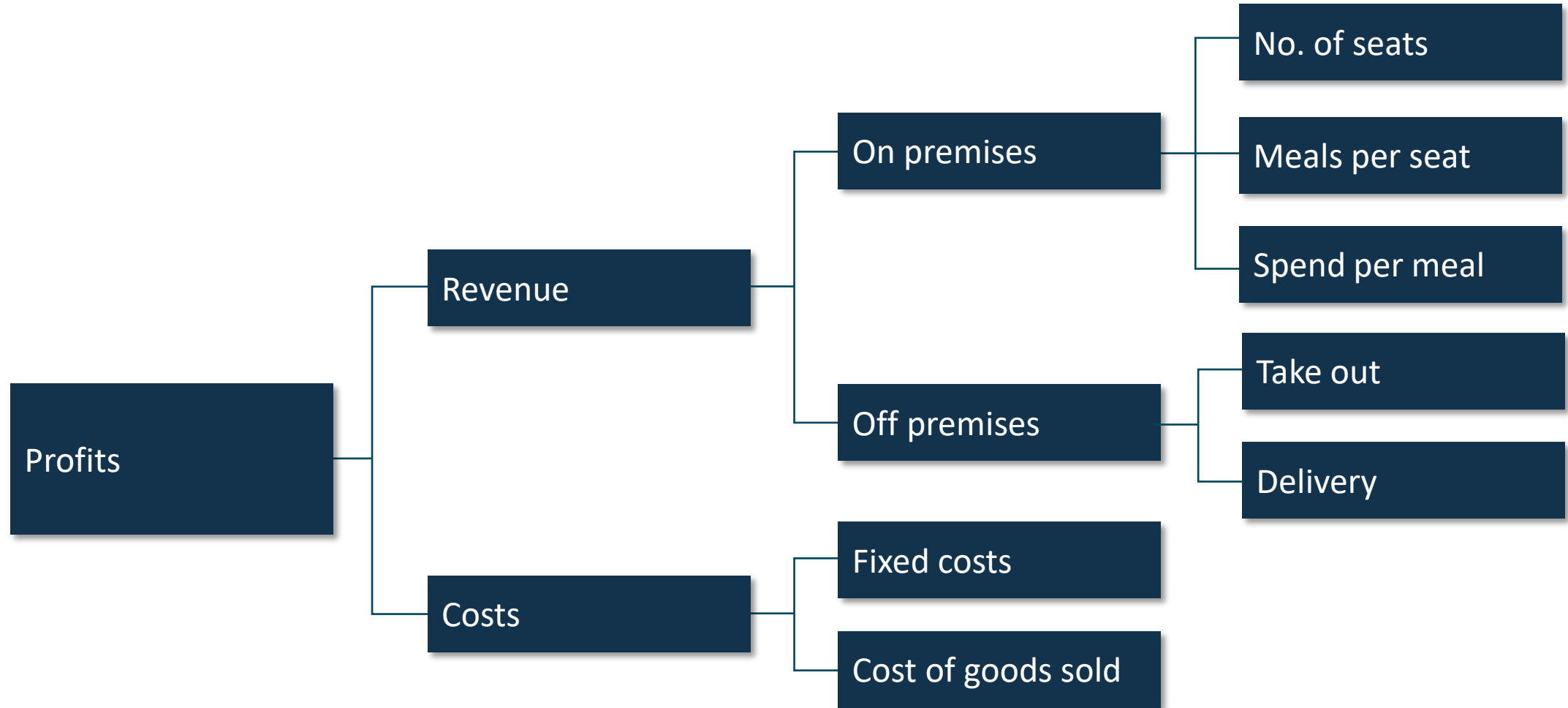
We could perform this exercise for any problem  
we are trying to solve

- How could this airline increase its profits?
- Should this car company launch a self-driving truck?
- What should this hotel chain's five-year strategy be?
- Should this biotech outsource its R&D?
- How can this mobile carrier reduce its call center costs?
- How should this bank respond to the new regulation?
- How can this logistics company leverage artificial intelligence?
- How could this non-profit increase donations?
- Should this university publish free classes online?
- How can London solve the homelessness crisis?



Your turn – let's try some examples

# Structuring example 1: How would you increase the profit of a restaurant?





## Structuring example 2: context and key question

- Your client is a leading retail bank offering residential mortgages, among other financial products.
- The overall number of mortgage applications that were started last year increased, however, the number of completed/issued mortgages decreased.
- The CEO has asked for your help in identifying a solution to this problem.
- How would you analyze this problem?



# Structuring example 2: possible approach

- **Issue with the quality of applications**
  - Engagement of applicants is declining (e.g., they make multiple applications online, they apply before getting their offer on a property is accepted)
  - The credit-worthiness of applicants is declining
- **Issue with our process**
  - Burdensome process leading to abandoned applications, customers choosing another bank
  - Offer not timely
  - Poor process once an offer is made
- **Issue with our offers**
  - Pricing/rates not competitive
  - Features/terms not attractive
  - Tighter approval rules

## Why this structure?

This structure is based on analysis of each of possible root causes of the decline in executed mortgages.

It also follows the key steps that an application would follow, from creation to completion.

It shows a good understanding of how loans are extended to consumers.



# Once you establish a sound approach, you can leverage your analytical skills to problem-solve

## Core analytical tools

- **Primary research:** interviews with experts, suppliers, customers, etc.
- **Secondary research:** publicly available data
- **Modeling:** market-derived demand models, valuation
- **Surveys:** collect population-specific data on select topics

## Typical business frameworks

- **Four Ps:** Product / Price / Promotion / Place
- **Three Cs:** Company, Competitors, Customers
- **Porter's Five Forces:** Customers / Competitors / Substitutes / New entrants / Suppliers
- **Supply / Demand**

## Data visualization tools

- **MS Excel:** data manipulation, quantitative analysis, trend and insight identification
- **MS PowerPoint:** charts, graphs, data tables
- **Tableau:** data maps, heat maps, interactive dashboards
- **Power BI:** data collection, modeling, interactive reports



## **Tips and tactics:** structured problem solving skills

- Structured problem solving is a muscle – you will improve with dedicated practice
- A good first step is to practice leveraging these skills when tackling cases or problems in your classes, life, etc.
- Once you begin your career search, you may be dedicating time toward developing this invaluable skill in preparation for your interviews
- Reflect often, you should gain more confidence and competence in this over time



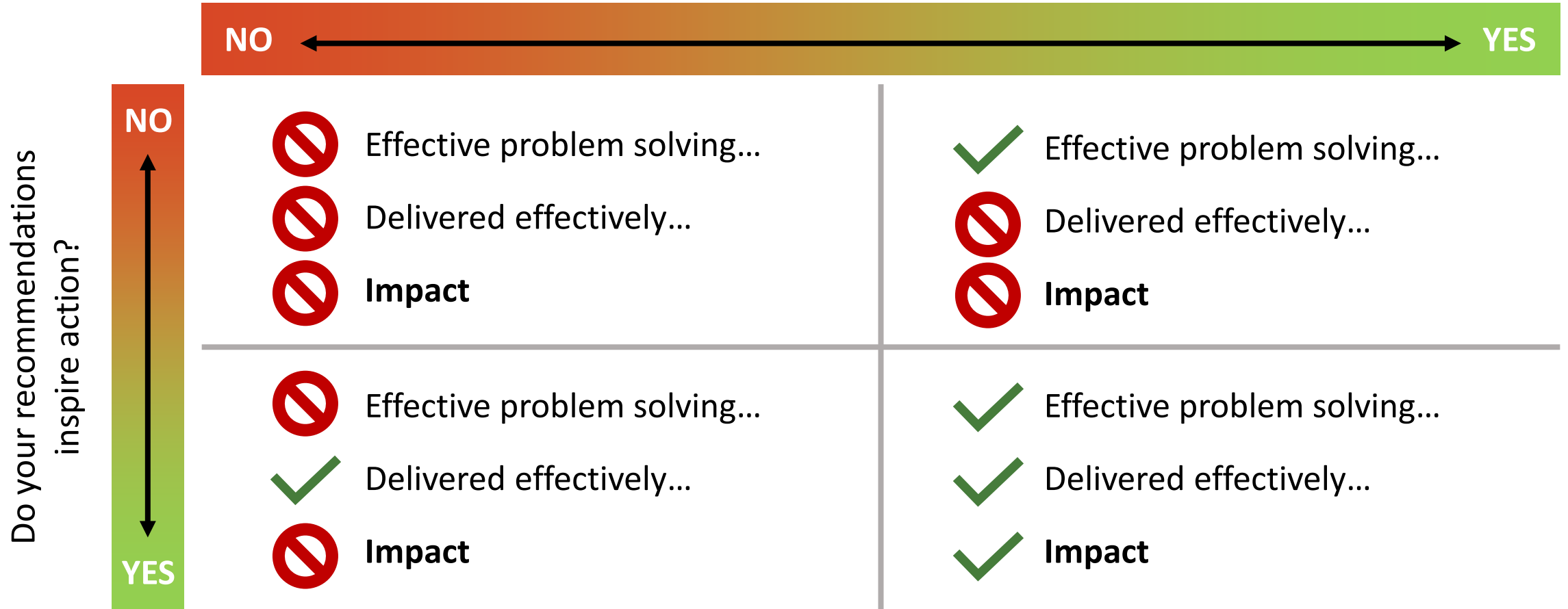
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# Solving the problem is only half of the battle...

Are your recommendations well-supported with data?



# High-impact communication has two distinct components



Communication  
**development**



Communication  
**delivery**

# High-impact communication has two distinct components



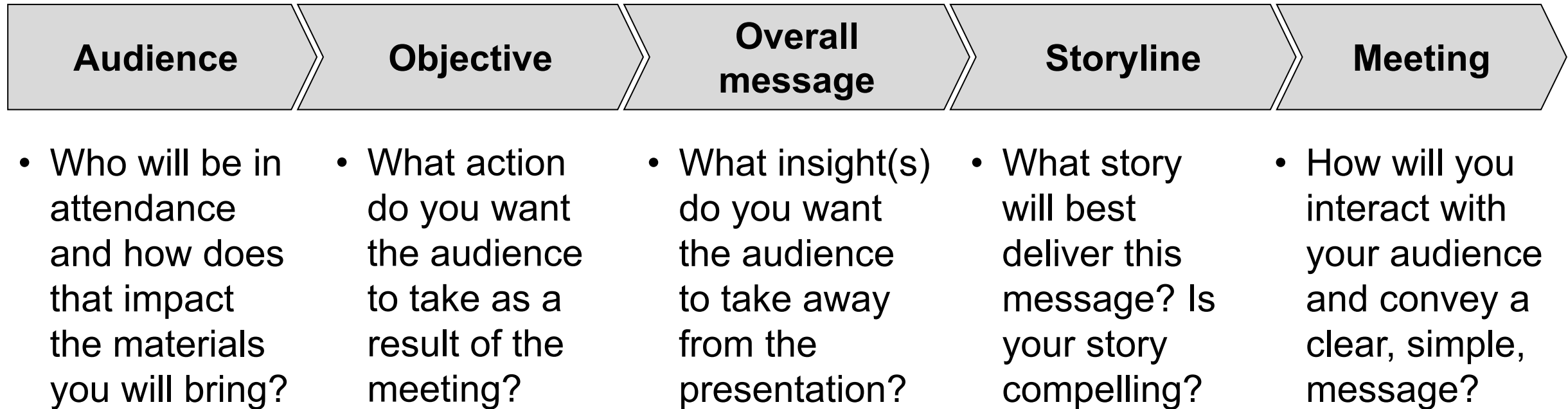
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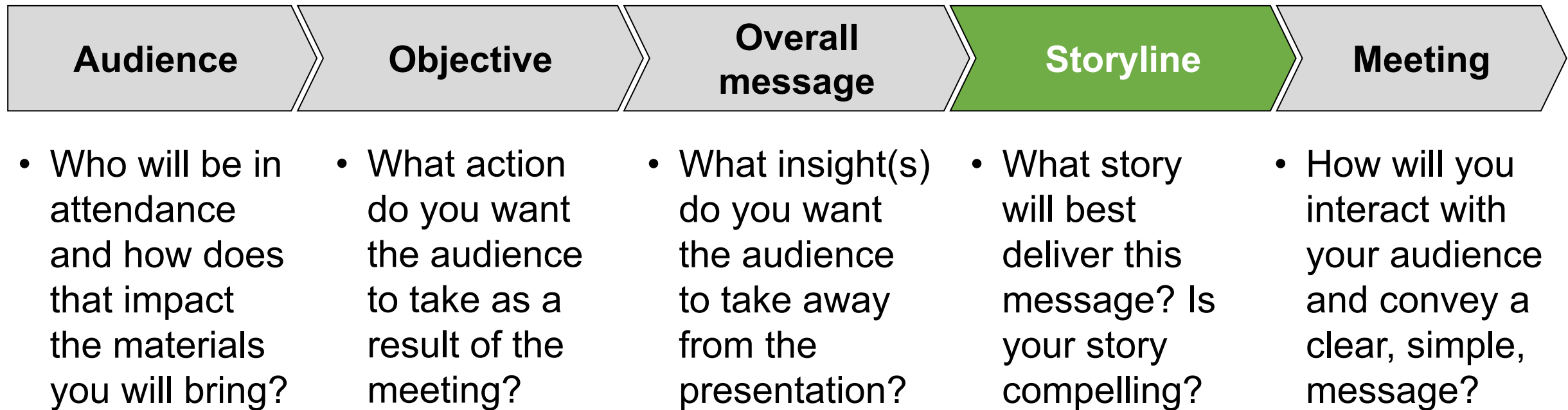


# High-impact communication begins with thoughtful consideration of your audience





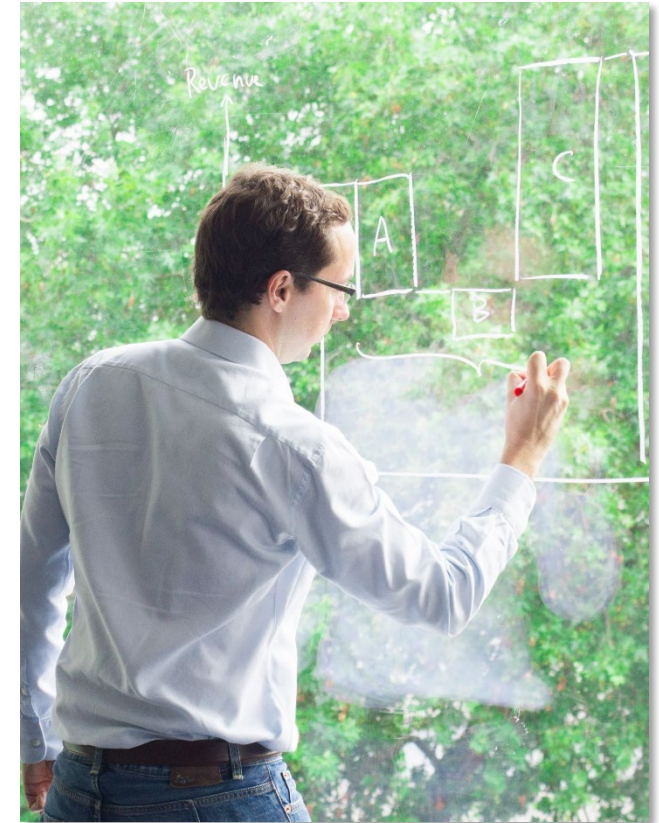
# High-impact communication begins with thoughtful consideration of your audience





# Your 'story' is a compelling narrative that organizes key insights and inspires action

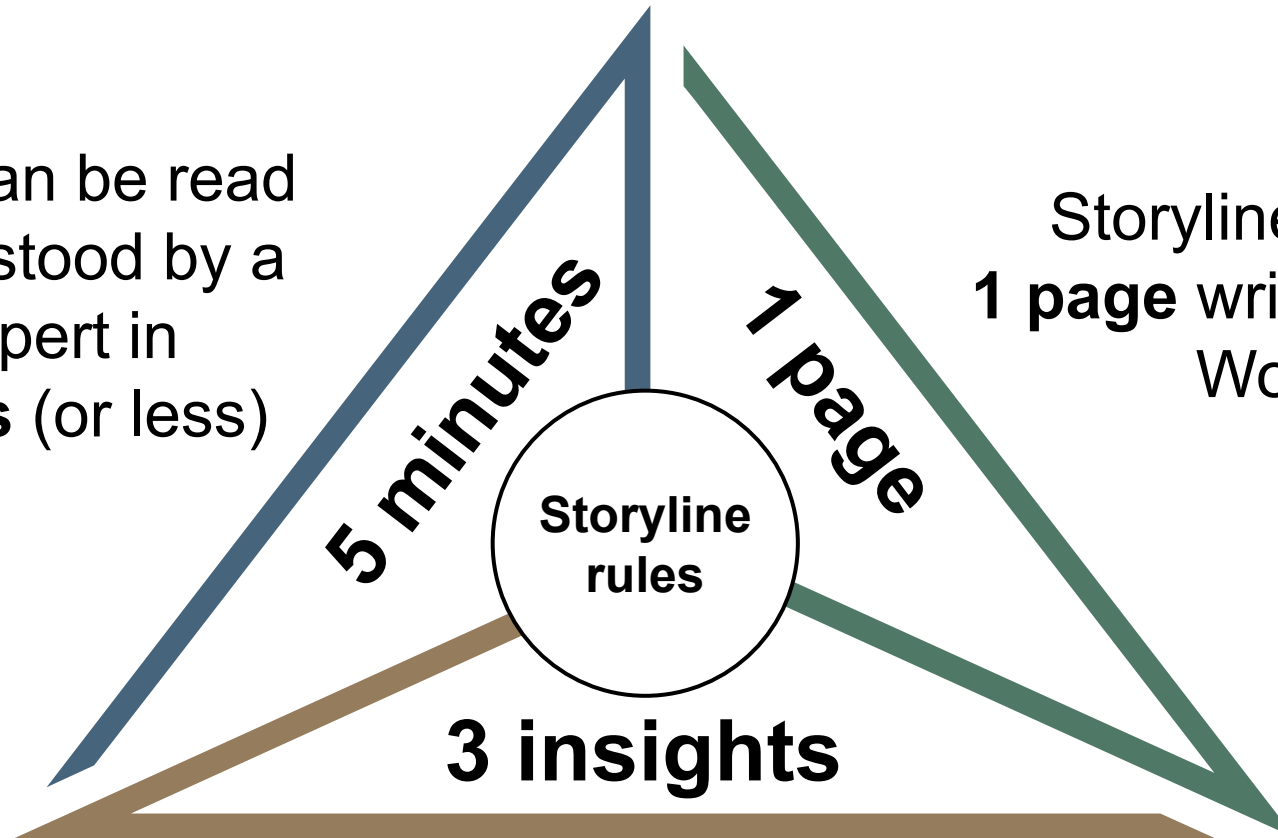
- Your 'storyline' is the way you **sequence information** and **build a well-supported argument** for your recommendation
- There are several common storyline flows
  - *Cause and effect*: this because of that – “Machine breakdowns in factories A & B are common because RetailCo began using different raw cotton materials”
  - *Linear sequence*: this, then this, then this – “The product is packaged, then it is loaded onto rail, then sent to distribution centers, where we find a stock surplus”
  - *Broad to specific*: big to small – “Now that we’ve seen the global picture, let’s focus on the Eastern region”
  - *Contributing factors*: break down the sources of the problem – “Your current situation has many contributing factors, external and internal.”



# When crafting your story, use the “1, 3, 5” rule

Storyline can be read  
and understood by a  
non-expert in  
**5 minutes** (or less)

Storyline fits on  
**1 page** written in MS  
Word



Storyline has **3 key insights** (or fewer)  
to support a single memorable message



# High-impact communication has two distinct components



Communication  
**development**



Communication  
**delivery**





# Sound logistics, careful word choice, effective visuals, good eye contact enhance delivery



## Logistics

---

**In-person** or virtual delivery?

Adjust your plan to **engage the audience** accordingly

Test **equipment** ahead of time



## Word choice

---

Think about **what you want to say**

Use **concise language**

Speak loudly enough and vary your **pace and pitch**



## Use of visuals

---

Insert **pauses** to allow audience to digest an exhibit

Begin with what the **slide** communicates

Discuss **insights and implications**



## Eye contact

---

Focus on the **audience**, not the slides

Look at **one person** at a time

Deliver **one thought** to each person



# Using directive language will help your audience focus on the right pieces of your message...

## Order

“We identified **four** sources of excessive capital expenditure: A, B, C and D. The **first** source, A, created deficits totaling...”

## Emphasize

“Downtime in the factory—the **most critical driver** of cost overruns—accounts for over 17%...”

## Repeat

“**Over 37%** of respondents targeted incorrect billing as their primary reason for switching suppliers. **37%, more than one-third of survey respondents...**”

## Restate

“Let’s examine the competitive landscape **another** way.”

## Focus

[While **referencing** a specific point] “**Note** the spike in fourth-quarter earnings. We attribute that to...”

## Bridge

“**So far**, we’ve examined the nature of the problem and isolated the root causes of... **Now** let’s focus on possible solutions.”



# ...while also improving your message clarity

## RECOMMENDATIONS

## AVOID USING...

## ...INSTEAD USE...

Use **active** voice  
vs. **passive** language

“The sample **was taken** from...”

“A team of 4 assemblers from the  
plant **took samples** from...”



# Tips and tactics for effective communication

- **Developing a strong presentation** begins with thoughtful planning:
  - Understand your audience
  - Clarify what you want your audience to take away from your presentation – then establish a clear, simple message
  - Develop a compelling storyline
  - Be thoughtful about how you plan to interact with your audience
- When **delivering your presentation**, invite the audience to engage, avoid jargon, use directive language and active speech, leverage visuals, and build a connection with audience members through eye contact



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## Key takeaways from this session

- You will use **structured problem solving** often – take the time to practice and master this valuable skill
- A **hypothesis-driven approach** to solving problems will ensure a sound and efficient analytical process
- The best solutions to problems are **well-supported** with data, analysis, and most importantly, **insights**
- Getting to the right answer is only half the battle – **communicating your solution** in a compelling manner is critical to **effecting change**



# Tuck Consulting Bootcamp: five-day virtual program to help further develop these skills

## GET CONSULTING READY: *MASTER YOUR STORY, THE CASE, AND THE INTERVIEW*

Offered by Dartmouth's top-ranked Tuck School of Business and led in partnership with Tuck's Career Services Office, this intensive, virtual program equips students interested in pursuing a career in consulting with the guidelines, knowledge, skills, and preparation necessary for succeeding in consulting interviews and the broader consulting recruiting process. Don't miss this chance to perfect your story, sharpen your case skills, and elevate your interview performance.



LEARN MORE AND ENROLL AT  
[UNDERGRAD.TUCK.DARTMOUTH.EDU](https://undergrad.tuck.dartmouth.edu)

### Dates

January 11–15, 2027 | 5-8 p.m. ET

### PROGRAM OVERVIEW

Whether you're exploring the field or actively preparing for interviews, you will:

- Have a deeper understanding of the consulting industry, projects, and lifestyle
- Master case interviews with proven frameworks and expert coaching
- Receive personalized feedback on your interactions
- Have the opportunity to network with experienced consultants and peers
- Access premium resources and insider insights from top consulting firms

MONDAY, JANUARY 11 | 5–8 P.M. ET | ZOOM

### Module 1 – Fundamentals of Consulting

Get an inside look at the consulting industry, recruiting timelines, and what top consulting firms value in candidates. Learn core business concepts and case interview basics. Connect with experienced consultants and Tuck alumni.

TUESDAY, JANUARY 12 | 5–8 P.M. ET | ZOOM

### Module 2 – Case Interviewing Fundamentals

Build a strong foundation in core business concepts and case interview fundamentals. Then, practice your first case in a guided group session, with personalized feedback throughout.

WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 13 | 5–8 P.M. ET | ZOOM

### Module 3 – Building Core Analytical Problem-solving Skills

Practice brainstorming techniques and tackle real interview prompts focused on exhibit interpretation and case math. Conclude the day by learning how to play the role of a case interviewer, giving you an opportunity to experience the "other side of the table."

THURSDAY, JANUARY 14 | 5–8 P.M. ET | ZOOM

### Module 4 – Case Interviewing in Practice and Effective Storytelling

Practice a full case interview by delivering and completing a peer-led mock case, with personalized feedback throughout. Learn how to craft compelling behavioral stories and build a consulting-ready resume. Explore the art of storytelling to elevate your fit interview skills to the next level.

FRIDAY, JANUARY 15 | 5–8 P.M. ET | ZOOM

### Module 5 – Advanced Casing & Behavioral Mastery

Elevate your casing with advanced strategies and full-length practice cases with feedback. Wrap up the day by developing a personalized preparation roadmap to guide next steps as you work toward a successful interview and coveted internship or full-time job offer.



# Other questions?

## **Andy Kaestle**

Adjunct Professor and Director of Career Services

Tuck School of Business at Dartmouth College